

#SheDIDIT • #SheFUND

Financial Inclusion and Entrepreneurial Empowerment among Migrant Women Entrepreneurs in Belgium

A consultancy report exploring how participation in #SheFUND, SheDIDIT's interest-free loan programme, contributes to migrant women entrepreneurs' skills, confidence, entrepreneurial identity, and perceived legitimacy.

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Executive Summary

The central case, in brief, before the evidence that supports it.

This report presents the findings of a qualitative study commissioned by #SheDIDIT and supported by the European Microfinance Network (EMN). The study examines how participation in #SheFUND shapes the skills, confidence, entrepreneurial identity, and perceived legitimacy of migrant women entrepreneurs in Belgium. It draws on semi-structured interviews conducted with funded entrepreneurs, applicants who were not selected for funding, coaching program participants, #SheDIDIT staff and coaches, and the funding partner. #SheFUND is an interest-free loan program delivered through MicroStart and embedded within #SheDIDIT's broader ecosystem of coaching, community, and entrepreneurial support. Since its launch in 2023, the program has run 3 editions, selected 7 beneficiaries across 47 applicants.

The central finding of this study is that #SheFUND should not be understood only as a loan product. Its transformative value lies in the full process through which women prepare, articulate, defend, and reposition their entrepreneurial projects. Across participants, the study finds that the program generates capability gains, strengthens confidence, supports entrepreneurial identity formation, and increases perceived legitimacy. These effects are visible not only among funded entrepreneurs, but also among women who applied, pitched, received feedback, or participated in the wider #SheDIDIT coaching ecosystem. Based on these findings, the report recommends that #SheDIDIT: treat community as a funded program output; standardise feedback for all #SheFUND applicants; address coaching capacity through group and peer formats; develop a pre entrepreneurial pathways; create a scale-up support after program completion; and make soft skills support a visible and evaluated component of coaching.

The study shows that #SheFUND produces more than access to finance. It produces confidence, legitimacy, social connection, entrepreneurial readiness, and a stronger capacity to navigate the Belgian entrepreneurial ecosystem. These outcomes are especially important for migrant women entrepreneurs, whose barriers to business development are not only financial, but also social, institutional, and mindset-related.

Following this executive summary, the report proceeds across nine chapters. Chapter 1 provides an introduction to the context and the research purpose. Chapter 2 describes the #SheFUND program in detail, including its underlying Theory of Change. Chapter 3 explains the research approach. Chapter 4 presents six key findings. Chapter 5 sets out additional emerging insights on demand at the edges of the #SheFUND journey. Chapter 6 presents a comparative analysis of the funded and not funded participant experiences. Chapter 7 presents six recommendations for #SheDIDIT. Chapter 8 sets out implications for the broader field. Chapter 9 concludes.

Key Findings

1

Community Is the Core Differentiator

Every participant, regardless of funding outcome, identifies belonging to a space that understands their intersectional experience as the single most impactful aspect of engagement. Community is not a peripheral feature. It is the foundation that makes the rest of the intervention effective.

2

Coaching Value Extends Beyond the Funded Cohort

The #SheFUND coaching curriculum delivers genuine technical value, but participants consistently point to something more transformative: a coach who listened without judgement, and a moment of recognition that made their ambition feel real. This value does not depend on being selected for funding.

3

Feedback Quality Shapes Applicant Outcomes

For non funded applicants, the quality of feedback after the pitch determines whether the experience empowers or erodes. A poorly managed non-selection risks undoing the confidence that the coaching phase worked to build.

4

The Loan Funds What Coaching Alone Cannot

Physical-product businesses face a hard financial floor before they can generate any revenue: minimum order quantities, tooling, packaging, and samples. No amount of planning, discipline, or business acumen substitutes for the capital itself.

5

The Loan Functions as Protected Capital

For founders who are also primary caregivers or sole earners, the loan is experienced as money that is functionally ring-fenced from the household budget — money they are permitted, practically and psychologically, to spend on the business without it costing their family something else.

6

The Loan Fills a Financing Access Gap

For migrant women without an established Belgian credit history, collateral, or professional network, conventional lenders are rarely a live alternative. The loan functions less as competitively-priced credit and more as the sole bridge between a validated idea and its execution.

Key Recommendations

01 · COMMUNITY

Name community as a core program output and fund it accordingly.

02 · FEEDBACK

Standardise and strengthen #SheFUND feedback for all applicants, funded or not.

03 · CAPACITY

Address the coaching capacity structurally through group formats and peer coaching.

04 · NEW PATHWAYS

Develop a pre-entrepreneurial pathway for adults, mirroring the YouthPreneurs model.

05 · NEW PATHWAYS

Create a post-graduation offer for scaling entrepreneurs who have outgrown the current coaching offer.

06 · WELL-BEING

Formalise soft skills training and psychological support as a named, visible, and evaluated feature of the coaching program.

Introduction and Context

Why migrant women entrepreneurs in Belgium face a compounded funding gap, and why #SheDIDIT was built to close it.

1.1 The Funding Gap for Migrant Women Entrepreneurs

Women entrepreneurs face a persistent and well documented funding gap. In Europe, women led firms receive substantially lower levels of bank financing, face higher collateral requirements, and are more frequently rejected for loans than comparable male led businesses, even after controlling for firm characteristics such as size, sector, and creditworthiness. The European Central Bank's Survey on the Access to Finance of Enterprises consistently shows that female led firms report greater unmet financing needs and more frequent use of informal funding sources. Globally, the picture is equally stark: a small fraction of venture capital investment reaches female founded businesses, and this proportion has remained largely unchanged for over a decade.

Migrant women entrepreneurs face compounded barriers. The gender gap intersects with language barriers, lower institutional familiarity, limited professional networks, the non-recognition of foreign credentials, and caregiving responsibilities that constrain working hours and constrain the ability to attend events, meet contacts, and build the informal relationships that sustain early-stage businesses. A migrant woman entrepreneur navigating the Belgian financial system faces not one set of exclusions but several, operating simultaneously and reinforcing each other.

Belgium presents a particularly relevant and instructive context for this study. Approximately one in three Belgians has a migration background, a proportion that is rising and that is not yet reflected in the country's entrepreneurial ecosystem, its financial institutions, or its policy infrastructure. Brussels, where #SheDIDIT is based, is one of the most diverse cities in Europe, with over 180 nationalities represented. Yet the entrepreneurial support ecosystem serving this population remains underdeveloped, and the microfinance landscape, though relatively advanced by European standards, has not consistently reached the most excluded segments of aspiring entrepreneurs.

The underrepresentation of migrant women in formal business ownership is not a reflection of lower ambition or capacity. It reflects structural exclusions that standard financial products and conventional business support services have failed to address. #SheDIDIT was founded to address precisely this gap, not by offering a modified version of existing services, but by building something qualitatively different: a support ecosystem rooted in the belief that potential is distributed equally, even when opportunity is not.

1.2 Purpose and Scope of This Report

This study was commissioned by #SheDIDIT and supported by the European Microfinance Network to generate qualitative evidence of #SheFUND's impact, not only on funded entrepreneurs, but on all women who participated in the application process. The study proceeds from the hypothesis that the structured journey of applying, preparing, and pitching for funding generates empowerment effects regardless of the financial outcome. If this hypothesis holds, it has significant implications for how the program is designed, evaluated, and communicated to funders, partners, and policymakers.

The central research questions of this study are:

How does participating in #SheFUND's loan selection and coaching process shape migrant women entrepreneurs' skills, confidence, and perceived legitimacy?

How do these experiences differ between those who receive funding and those who do not?

These questions are addressed through a qualitative study with a selected sample of participants spanning all stages and outcomes of the #SheFUND program.

The study has four specific objectives:

1. To assess the impact of #SheFUND's full loan selection process and types of coaching across the participant population;
2. To compare the experiences of funded and not funded entrepreneurs and identify learning and empowerment mechanisms across both groups;
3. To assess how #SheDIDIT's ecosystem influences entrepreneurial identity, perceived legitimacy, and business development practices;
4. To generate actionable insights for #SheDIDIT and reflective observations for the EMN and the broader field.

1.3 About #SheDIDIT

#SheDIDIT was founded by a Belgian entrepreneur, who experienced firsthand both the barriers faced by women with a migration background in Belgium's entrepreneurial ecosystem and the transformative potential of targeted and culturally sensitive support.

The organisation's founding philosophy is articulated clearly in a conversation with the CEO & Founder:

“There are people of whom talent goes to waste because they don’t know where to start or where to go. We want to change the image of the entrepreneur and make it as normal as possible that everybody can be an entrepreneur, that everybody can recognize themselves in the image.”

“We choose to see diversity as a strength. Our approach is really different because we say, okay, it should be normal that you, wearing a headscarf, are also attending this New Year’s reception of the Chamber of Commerce out of your talent and passion. It’s only our role to unlock it, but you can do it yourself.”

This framing, beginning with potential rather than disadvantage, is not merely rhetorical. It shapes every decision the organisation has made, from the composition of the #SheFUND jury (women focused and entrepreneurially literate, by deliberate design) to the structure of the #SheMeansBusiness coaching program (practical, iterative, and built around the participant’s existing knowledge and ambition). It also shapes the relational tone of the organisation’s interactions with participants, which the evidence in this study identifies as a core differentiator.

#SheDIDIT operates a portfolio of four programs. #SheMeansBusiness is a 7 session coaching program for pre starters and early-stage entrepreneurs, covering business planning, financial modelling, pricing strategy, market analysis, and pitch preparation. #SheHub is a physical coworking space for registered businesses, providing workspace, community, and access to a professional network. #YouthPreneurs is a summer school and coaching program for aspiring entrepreneurs aged 15 to 28, offering an exploratory, identity oriented entry point to entrepreneurship. #SheFUND is the alternative lending product that is the central focus of this study.

The #SheFUND Program

Design, philosophy, journey, evolution, and the underlying Theory of Change.

2.1 #SheFUND Design and Philosophy

#SheFUND was launched by #SheDIDIT in 2023 as a structured microfinance product designed specifically for migrant women entrepreneurs in Belgium. Delivered in partnership with MicroStart, Belgium's leading microfinance institution, #SheFUND offers interest free loans of up to 10,000 euro to business owners who have demonstrated potential through a structured selection process. The program is not designed to serve any migrant woman entrepreneur who applies. It is designed to serve those who are ready: women who have completed coaching, developed a business plan, and are prepared to defend their model to an external jury.

This design philosophy reflects a deliberate positioning. #SheFUND is not a safety net. It is a springboard. The program's target beneficiary is a woman who has a viable business, has done the work to understand her market and her finances, and needs a specific and time sensitive capital injection to take the next step. This profile stands in contrast to the typical beneficiary profile of deficit oriented microfinance programs, which often serve women at the very earliest and most fragile stages of entrepreneurial aspiration, before they have developed the capacity to deploy capital effectively.

The MicroStart partnership is central to program delivery. MicroStart administers the loan disbursement, handles repayment, and manages any defaults. #SheDIDIT manages the selection process, coaching requirement, and post decision engagement. This division of roles means that #SheFUND beneficiaries receive both financial infrastructure from MicroStart and social infrastructure from #SheDIDIT. The two organisations are complementary rather than duplicative, and the partnership model is one of the program's most replicable features.

2.2 #SheFUND Loan Characteristics

The #SheFUND loan product has the following features: loan amounts from zero to 10,000 euro; a zero percent interest rate; a five percent one time administration fee; lump sum disbursement via MicroStart; a grace period of three to six months before repayments begin; a repayment term of 36 months; and no collateral requirement. In the event of non repayment, the pathway follows deferral, then restructuring, then third party collection as a last resort, with an emphasis throughout on maintaining the relationship with the borrower rather than on debt recovery.

The zero-interest structure is a significant differentiator from conventional microfinance products in Belgium and from commercial lending more broadly. It reflects the program's empowerment rather than commercial orientation: the goal is to remove financial barriers to growth, not to generate a return on capital. This distinction matters to participants. It signals that the institution trusts them, that the loan is an investment in their potential rather than a commercial transaction.

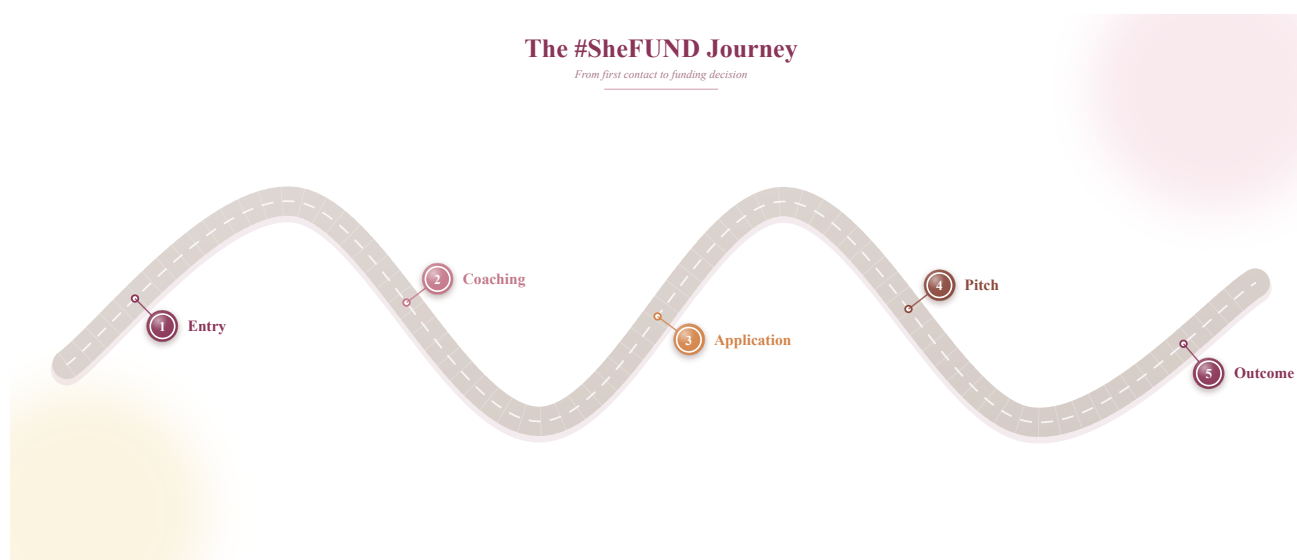
Repayment has generally proceeded without major difficulty among the beneficiaries in this study. Participants attribute this partly to the grace period, which allowed them to generate revenue before repayments began, and partly to the financial discipline instilled through the coaching program. No participant in the sample reported default or significant repayment difficulty at the time of interview.

As #SheDIDIT's CEO & Founder explains:

"When people give you money, it is not only about the money. It is more about trust, confidence."

2.3 #SheFUND Applicant Journey

The #SheFUND applicant journey unfolds across 5 key phases, as presented below. Each phase has a distinct function, and the evidence from this study shows that empowerment effects operate at every stage, not only at the moment of selection.



2.4 Evolution Across Editions

The program has evolved substantially across its three editions, reflecting #SheDIDIT's commitment to learning from each cycle and refining the model in response to evidence and experience.

The 2023 inaugural edition took the form of a pitch competition. It drew 28 candidates, operated without a mandatory coaching prerequisite, and selected 5 winners at a public award ceremony. This edition established #SheFUND as a visible and distinctive feature of Brussels's entrepreneurial landscape, attracting media attention and building #SheDIDIT's profile. However, the absence of a coaching prerequisite meant that the application and pitching experience was less consistently empowering: without a shared preparation framework, applicants' readiness varied considerably.

The 2024 edition introduced two significant structural changes: a two-stage selection process, in which written applications were screened before candidates were invited to pitch; and the #SheMeansBusiness coaching prerequisite, which became mandatory for #SheFUND application from this edition onwards. These changes raised the quality and consistency of applications, deepened the connection between non-financial services and financial access, and created a more defensible and replicable model. Ten applications were received; five were selected to pitch; two were ultimately funded.

The 2025 transition edition maintained the 2024 structure with minor adjustments. Nine applications were received; five were selected for the pitch stage; one was funded. The lower funding rate reflects stricter selection criteria and a more demanding jury process rather than reduced program ambition. The three editions together demonstrate a deliberate trajectory: from a visibility focused event toward a precision impact focused program.

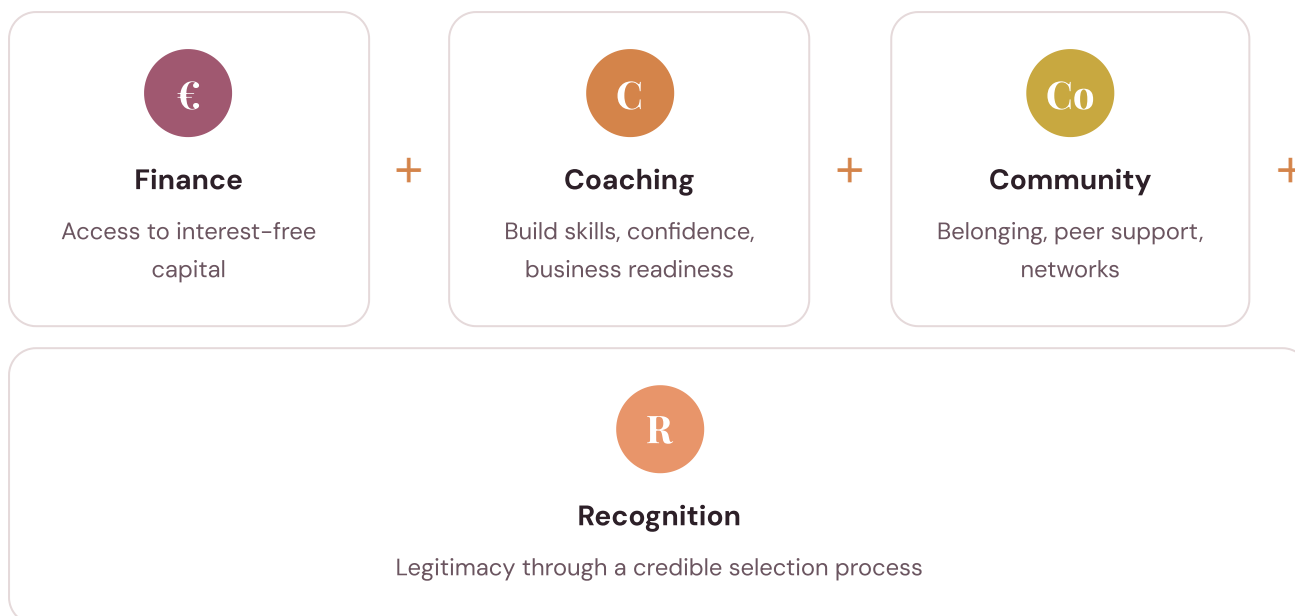
2.5 #SheFUND Theory of Change

“The potential is there within you, and it is our role to unlock it.”

Based on the findings presented in Chapter 4, this report develops a Theory of Change specific to the #SheFUND program. The purpose of the Theory of Change is to make explicit how #SheFUND creates impact, through which mechanisms, and at which stages of the participant journey. It also helps clarify that #SheFUND should not be understood only as a loan mechanism. Its impact comes from the combination of finance, coaching, community, and recognition, which together support migrant women entrepreneurs before, during, and after the funding decision.

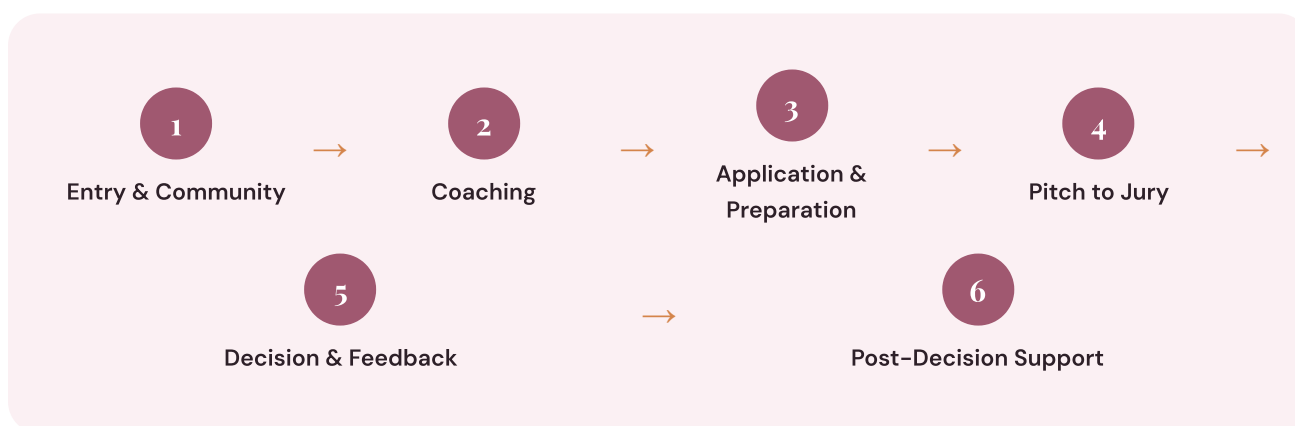
The starting assumption of the Theory of Change is that migrant women entrepreneurs face barriers that are not only financial. Limited access to capital is important, but it is only one part of a wider set of constraints. Participants may also face limited networks, lack of familiarity with the Belgian entrepreneurial ecosystem, low confidence in formal business spaces, language insecurity, limited access to tailored coaching, and a lack of recognition as legitimate entrepreneurs. For this reason, a financial product alone is unlikely to generate the full range of outcomes that #SheFUND seeks to produce. Capital becomes more effective when it is embedded in a support system that also builds confidence, business readiness, community, and perceived legitimacy.

The #SheFUND model works through four mutually reinforcing inputs:



These four inputs are not independent components. Their value lies in how they interact. Coaching is more effective when participants feel safe and understood within a trusted community. Finance becomes more meaningful when it is experienced not only as money, but as a signal of confidence in the entrepreneur. Recognition becomes more powerful when it is attached to a public process of application, pitching, and jury evaluation. Community helps ensure that the experience remains valuable even for those who do not receive funding, because participants still leave with stronger confidence, clearer business language, and a sense of belonging to an entrepreneurial ecosystem.

The Theory of Change therefore positions the #SheDIDIT journey as the central pathway through which impact is produced:



The journey begins with entry and community, where women encounter #SheDIDIT, feel seen, and build initial trust. It then moves into coaching, where participants develop technical and soft skills, work on mindset, and increase confidence. The application and preparation stage requires participants to define their business, articulate their financial needs, and translate their entrepreneurial idea into a structured proposal. The pitch to the jury becomes a moment of public entrepreneurial performance, where participants gain visibility, practice storytelling, and build self belief. The decision and feedback stage

provides either access to finance or an opportunity for redirection and learning. Finally, the post decision stage can sustain impact through ongoing guidance, referrals, alumni connection, and continued community engagement.

SHORT-TERM · 0–6 MONTHS

Immediate capabilities

- ✓ Stronger business knowledge and skills
- ✓ Increased confidence and self-efficacy
- ✓ Clearer business model and direction
- ✓ Stronger entrepreneurial identity
- ✓ Perceived legitimacy and validation

MEDIUM-TERM · 6–24 MONTHS

Ecosystem embeddedness

- ✓ Business continuity and growth
- ✓ Better access to networks and clients
- ✓ Greater readiness to seek finance
- ✓ Deeper engagement in the ecosystem
- ✓ Contribution back to the community

LONG-TERM · 2+ YEARS

Systemic impact

- ✓ More inclusive entrepreneurial ecosystem
- ✓ Greater financial inclusion
- ✓ More sustainable women-led businesses
- ✓ Stronger economic & social participation

The short term outcomes of this pathway are expected to emerge within the first six months. These outcomes are important because they represent the immediate capabilities that allow participants to move from aspiration to action. They also show that impact begins before the loan is disbursed and extends beyond funded entrepreneurs.

In the medium term, #SheFUND is expected to contribute to business continuity and growth, better access to networks and clients, greater readiness to seek finance, deeper engagement in the entrepreneurial ecosystem, and contribution back to the #SheDIDIT community. At this stage, the value of the program becomes visible not only in individual business development, but also in stronger social and entrepreneurial embeddedness. Participants are better positioned to navigate the ecosystem, use the skills developed during coaching, and mobilize the confidence and networks gained through the program.

The long term impact of #SheFUND is expected to unfold and contribute to a more inclusive entrepreneurial ecosystem, greater financial inclusion, more sustainable women led businesses, and stronger economic and social participation among migrant women entrepreneurs in Belgium. These impacts depend on the cumulative effect of the earlier stages. They are unlikely to result from finance alone. Rather, they emerge when capital is combined with coaching, community, recognition, and continued connection.

When migrant women entrepreneurs receive capital together with coaching, community and recognition, they do not only access finance: they become more confident, more visible, more connected and better prepared to grow.

Research Approach

Design, sample, data collection, analysis, and the limitations of this study.

3.1 Research Design

This study adopts a qualitative research design to examine how #SheFUND shapes the entrepreneurial trajectories, perceived capabilities, confidence, identity, and legitimacy of migrant women entrepreneurs. The research is exploratory in nature and is concerned not only with identifying program outcomes, but also with understanding the mechanisms through which those outcomes are produced. For this reason, a qualitative approach is particularly appropriate. It allows the analysis to capture participants' subjective experiences, interpretations, relational dynamics, and meaning making processes, which are central to understanding empowerment-oriented interventions but are often difficult to observe through quantitative indicators alone.

The study is designed around the question of how #SheFUND works, for whom, and under what conditions. Rather than treating the program solely as a financial instrument, the research examines #SheFUND as a broader support process embedded in coaching, community, public recognition, feedback, and institutional validation. This required a research strategy capable of reconstructing the participant journey across different stages, from first contact with #SheDIDIT to coaching, application, pitching, funding decisions, and post decision trajectories.

In-depth semi-structured interviews were used as the primary method of data collection. This method was selected because it provides sufficient structure to ensure comparability across participants while also allowing respondents to elaborate on their personal histories, entrepreneurial aspirations, challenges, and experiences of the program in their own terms. The interview data were supplemented by document review and process reconstruction through interviews with staff, coaches, and external stakeholders. This combination of sources allowed the analysis to connect individual experiences with the wider organizational design and implementation logic of #SheFUND.

3.2 Participants and Sampling Strategy

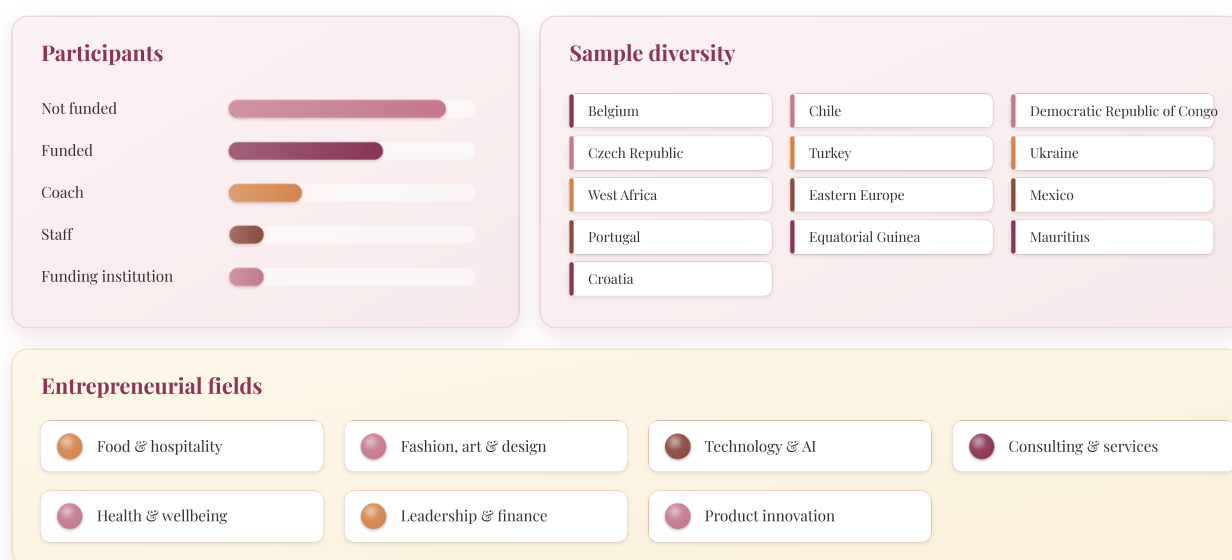
The study draws on interviews with individuals across three broad participant categories: (i) funded entrepreneurs, (ii) non-funded entrepreneurs and (iii) organizational stakeholders, including staff, coaches, and the external funding partner. This multi perspective design was adopted to capture both the lived experience of women entrepreneurs and the institutional perspective of actors involved in designing, delivering, and supporting the program.

Participants were recruited through purposive sampling facilitated by #SheDIDIT. The aim was not to produce a statistically representative sample, but to ensure analytical variation across relevant dimensions, including program edition, funding outcome, national background, entrepreneurial sector, and stage of engagement with #SheDIDIT. This was important because the study seeks to understand the

value generated by #SheFUND beyond the final funding decision, including how the process affects women who participate in coaching, apply, pitch, or receive feedback but do not ultimately receive financial support.

The inclusion of staff, coaches, and the external funding partner served two purposes. First, these interviews helped reconstruct the program process, including its intended objectives, selection mechanisms, coaching components, and feedback practices. Second, they provided a basis for triangulating participants' accounts and interpreting how individual experiences relate to organizational design choices. All participants gave informed consent prior to interview. Names and identifying details have been anonymized to protect confidentiality, and findings are presented in a way that avoids attributing sensitive or identifiable information to individual respondents.

Below is presented a summary of the sample of participants of this study.



3.3 Data Collection

Data collection relied primarily on semi structured interviews. Separate interview protocols were developed for different respondent groups.

For funded entrepreneurs, the interview guide focused on the entrepreneurial background of the participant, the pathway into #SheDIDIT and #SheFUND, the experience of coaching and application preparation, the pitch and selection process, the use and perceived meaning of the loan, and the broader effects of participation on skills, confidence, legitimacy, and business development.

For non-funded entrepreneurs and coaching participants, the interview guide covered similar themes but placed greater emphasis on the experience of not being selected, the quality and usefulness of feedback, the emotional and practical consequences of the decision, and the extent to which participants remained

connected to #SheDIDIT after the process. This distinction was important because the study does not assume that impact is limited to funded beneficiaries. Instead, it examines whether and how the application and coaching journey itself generates value, even when it does not result in financial support.

A separate shorter protocol was developed for staff, coaches, and stakeholders. These interviews focused on program objectives, implementation choices, selection criteria, perceived strengths and weaknesses, participant needs, and opportunities for future improvement. In combination, the three interview protocols allowed the study to examine #SheFUND from multiple angles: as a participant experience, as an organizational intervention, and as a funding and support mechanism.

Interviews were conducted in English and lasted between 40 and 70 minutes. With participants' consent, interviews were audio recorded and transcribed. Transcripts were subsequently reviewed manually to correct transcription errors, improve accuracy, and ensure that meaning was preserved. In addition to interview data, relevant program documents were reviewed to contextualize the findings and support the reconstruction of the #SheFUND process.

3.4 Data Analysis

The analysis followed an abductive thematic approach. This approach combines sensitivity to existing analytical concepts with openness to themes emerging from the data. It was appropriate for this study because the research was guided by a set of core dimensions, including skills and capabilities, entrepreneurial identity, confidence, perceived legitimacy, and community, while also allowing new themes to emerge inductively from participants' accounts.

The coding process developed iteratively. An initial codebook was constructed on the basis of the research objectives and the first set of interviews. This codebook included deductive categories related to the expected areas of program impact, such as business skills, financial literacy, pitch readiness, entrepreneurial confidence, legitimacy, network access, and post decision trajectories. During early coding, additional themes were added to capture issues that emerged from the data, including emotional safety, peer recognition, the meaning of being taken seriously, the role of community, the experience of rejection, and the importance of feedback quality.

The first interviews were coded closely to refine the codebook and clarify coding boundaries. The full dataset was then coded consistently using the revised structure. The analysis proceeded through several stages. First, within case analysis was used to reconstruct each participant's journey and identify how she experienced different phases of the program. Second, cross case analysis was used to compare patterns across funded and non funded participants. This comparison was particularly important for identifying which forms of value were specific to funded entrepreneurs and which were generated through the broader #SheFUND process. Third, stakeholder and staff interviews were used to triangulate findings and connect participant experiences to the program's design and implementation features.

The final themes were developed by moving iteratively between the coded material, the research questions, and the emerging interpretation of #SheFUND as more than a loan mechanism. This analytical process led to the identification of several core mechanisms, including capability building, confidence

formation, entrepreneurial identity work, perceived legitimacy, community embeddedness, and feedback as a critical turning point in the participant journey.

3.5 Limitations

It is important to acknowledge that this study has limitations mostly linked to the small sample size. As a result, findings should not be interpreted as generalizable. The study relies primarily on self-reported experiences. For these reasons, the findings should be understood as analytical and explanatory rather than causal in a strict evaluation sense.

Despite these limitations, the qualitative design provides rich insight into the mechanisms through which #SheFUND creates value. It is particularly well suited to capturing forms of impact that are central to the program but difficult to measure through standard financial indicators alone, including confidence, legitimacy, community, identity, and readiness to continue the entrepreneurial journey.

Key Findings

Six findings emerge consistently across all participant groups in this study.

Six findings emerge consistently across all participant groups in this study. They hold across funding outcome, national background, sector, and stage of entrepreneurial development. Together they paint a coherent and actionable picture of what #SheFUND actually does, for whom, and how.

1

Community as #SheDIDIT's most powerful differentiator

Every participant, regardless of funding outcome, program phase, or national background, identifies belonging to a space that understands their intersectional experience as migrants, women, and entrepreneurs as the single most impactful aspect of engagement. Community is not a peripheral feature. It is the foundation that makes the rest of the intervention effective: the mechanism through which coaching becomes credible, the pitch meaningful, and non-selection survivable.

1.1 Community as enabling infrastructure

The most consistent finding across the interviews is that community is not a peripheral feature of #SheDIDIT's work. It is the foundation that makes the rest of the intervention effective.

Participants repeatedly describe #SheDIDIT not only as an organization that offers training, coaching, or access to finance, but as a space in which they feel understood, recognized, and taken seriously as migrant women entrepreneurs.

"I was rebuilding myself from scratch. Professionally, personally. All I was searching for was the right people. People I could trust. #SheDIDIT was foundational to my business."

It was often highlighted how many entrepreneurship support programs provide technical assistance but fewer create an environment in which participants feel that their specific social position, as women, migrants, founders, mothers, newcomers, racialized entrepreneurs, or non-native speakers, is seen as part of the entrepreneurial journey rather than treated as an obstacle to be overcome individually.

One participant captured this tension when reflecting on the difficulty of balancing entrepreneurship and care responsibilities:

“I also have to find the balance between being a mama and finding time for myself. In the last five years that didn’t happen too much.”

For these reasons, community emerges as #SheDIDIT’s most powerful differentiator. It is not simply an addition to the program. It is a mechanism of trust formation. Participants are more willing to share doubts, disclose uncertainty, ask basic questions, receive feedback, and expose unfinished ideas because the environment is perceived as safe and not judgmental. This matters because early-stage entrepreneurship is rarely experienced as a purely technical process. It is also emotional, relational, and identity based. Women are not only learning how to structure a business plan or prepare a pitch. They are also learning how to see themselves as entrepreneurs, how to speak with confidence about their work, and how to claim legitimacy in spaces where they may not have previously felt entitled to belong.

“That feeling of not being alone at the top. It was very nice to have that help.”

1.2 Trust as a mechanism of participation

Community function strengthens the effectiveness of coaching. Coaching is not received as business advice delivered from above, but as support embedded in a relationship of recognition. Participants are therefore more likely to interpret feedback as constructive rather than discouraging, and more likely to translate it into action. In this sense, community improves the credibility of the technical components of the program. It makes business development support feel accessible, relevant, and personally meaningful. The same applies to the pitch process. The public act of presenting a business idea becomes less intimidating when it is situated within a community that has already helped participants rehearse, refine, and believe in their entrepreneurial narrative.

Peer ties were also described as an important part of this process:

“...with time, we just really became like, sort of buddies... we would check on each other.”

Another participant similarly emphasized the emotional value of being part of a shared space:

“It always felt so good to be understood, shared about our worries and getting also so much support and so much love from the community.”

1.3 Community reframes the funding decision

Community changes the meaning of the funding decision:

For funded entrepreneurs, receiving support through #SheFUND is experienced not only as access to capital, but as a signal of trust and validation from a community that understands their journey.

For non-funded participants, community made rejection more accepted and understood. Not being selected is perceived as disappointing, but when the decision is embedded in a broader support system, it becomes interpreted as a moment of redirection rather than as a final judgement on entrepreneurial worth.

On this matter, one of the entrepreneurs, even after a negative funding outcome, reinforced her perception of the value of the community saying:

“It also helped me to get resources to network with other people.”

This is one of the most important findings of the study. The value of #SheFUND is not tied only to the loan. It is produced through the whole process and community is what allows that process to remain valuable even when the financial outcome is negative.

This finding has important implications for how #SheDIDIT understands and communicates its impact. Community is often difficult to quantify and is therefore at risk of being treated as secondary to more visible outputs, such as number of applicants, loans disbursed, coaching hours, or businesses funded. Yet the interviews suggest that community is the infrastructure through which these outputs become meaningful. Without community, coaching would likely become more transactional, pitching more intimidating, feedback more fragile, and non selection more discouraging. Community is therefore not a “soft” outcome. It is a productive asset that enables capability development, confidence building, identity formation, and continued engagement.

1.4 Strategic Implications

Strategically, this means that #SheDIDIT should treat community as a core program component rather than as an informal by product of its work. The community function should be deliberately designed, funded, staffed, and measured. This could include structured peer interaction before and after the pitch, alumni engagement, facilitated spaces for non funded applicants, founder circles, peer mentoring, and community based follow up after the funding decision. It also means that funders should be encouraged to recognize community building as part of the intervention model, not as an administrative or communication activity.

The broader implication is that #SheDIDIT occupies a distinctive position in Belgium’s entrepreneurial support landscape. Its uniqueness does not lie only in serving migrant women entrepreneurs, nor only in offering interest free loans through #SheFUND. Its distinctive value lies in combining financial access with a community that produces recognition, trust, and belonging. This combination is difficult to

replicate because it depends on relational credibility, lived experience, and sustained engagement with the target community. Community is therefore both #SheDIDIT's most defensible differentiator and its most underleveraged strategic asset.

2

Coaching Value Extends Beyond the Funded Cohort

The #SheFUND coaching curriculum delivers genuine technical value – business planning, financial literacy, pricing strategy – but participants consistently point to something more transformative: a coach who listened without judgement, and a moment of recognition that made their ambition feel real. Preparing an application and pitching require the same identity work regardless of the funding decision. Critically, this value does not depend on being selected: non funded participants in this study continued running their businesses, sought alternative funding, and in several cases directly applied what they had learned to grow their activities. Reporting only on funded participants' outcomes would mean systematically underreporting the program's overall impact.

2.1 The relevance of soft skills

This finding also concerns the central role of soft skills in the #SheFUND coaching model. The coaching program provides substantive technical content, including business planning, financial modelling, pricing strategy, customer definition, and the business model canvas. Participants recognize the value of these tools and often refer to them as useful for structuring their ideas, clarifying their business model, and preparing for the pitch. However, when asked what changed most through their participation, most participants do not first refer to a worksheet, a financial template, or a specific business planning tool. They refer instead to confidence, clarity, self-belief, encouragement, and the feeling of being listened by their coach without judgement.

“Making a financial plan, you can learn that from tutorials. The most valuable thing is identifying when someone is struggling with self-confidence and helping them make the mental click.”

This does not mean that technical skills are irrelevant. Rather, the interviews suggest that technical skills become even more meaningful when they are delivered through a relational and psychologically safe process.

Confidence development builds entrepreneurial legitimacy

Many participants entered the program with ideas, experience, creativity, or sector specific expertise, but lacked the confidence to translate these resources into a coherent entrepreneurial narrative. For them, the challenge was not only to learn business language, but to feel entitled to use it. Coaching therefore worked not simply as knowledge transfer, but as a process through which women were helped to organize their ideas, name their value, and present themselves as legitimate entrepreneurs.

One participant described the coach as the missing link between her existing capacity and her ability to act on it:

“I knew that I had the capacity, I had the knowledge... I just needed this bridge, and that was what my business coach gave to me.”

“I’m actually executing what my business coach told me, and it works. I am earning money from that.”

Soft skills as practical entrepreneurial capabilities

In this sense, soft skills should not be understood as secondary to technical skills. In the context of early-stage migrant women entrepreneurship, they are often the condition that allows technical skills to be used. Confidence affects whether a participant asks questions, attends events, approaches partners, speaks to customers, applies for funding, or stands in front of a jury. Communication skills affect whether she can explain her project convincingly. Emotional resilience affects whether she continues after a setback. Self presentation affects whether her business is perceived as credible by external audiences. These are not marginal outcomes. They are practical entrepreneurial capabilities.

The interviews show that #SheFUND’s strongest contribution often lies in this less visible domain. Participants describe coaches who listened carefully, created space for doubt, and helped them transform uncertainty into action. They describe moments of recognition in which their business idea became more concrete because someone else treated it as serious and worth developing. These experiences may appear intangible, but they have concrete effects on how participants move through the entrepreneurial process.

One participant summarized this clearly:

“What I appreciated the most was the mental support, the psychological support. I was kind of lost. Just having a coach that could listen to me and reassure me.. that’s what I appreciated the most.”

This finding is especially important because migrant women entrepreneurs may face barriers that are not only financial or technical. They may also face limited networks, unfamiliarity with the local business environment, language insecurity, lack of institutional confidence, discrimination, care responsibilities, or previous experiences of not being taken seriously. In this context, providing technical content alone is unlikely to be sufficient. A business model canvas can help structure an idea, but it cannot by itself overcome the hesitation to claim entrepreneurial legitimacy. A financial model can support planning, but it does not automatically produce the confidence to negotiate, pitch, or ask for investment. #SheDIDIT's value lies in combining these technical tools with the relational conditions that allow participants to internalize and use them.

“The most valuable thing... they make us feel we are not alone and everything is possible.”

Why Soft Skills Must Be Named and Measured

The program therefore produces a form of impact that is easy to underestimate because it is not always immediately visible in conventional monitoring indicators. Confidence, voice, clarity, and resilience may not appear as direct business outputs, but they are part of the infrastructure of entrepreneurial action. They shape whether participants continue developing their projects, whether they interpret setbacks as failure or learning, and whether they remain connected to support networks after the program ends. For funded participants, these soft skill gains can strengthen their ability to use financial support effectively. For non funded participants, they can determine whether non selection becomes discouragement or redirection.

Strategically, this suggests that #SheDIDIT should name, measure, and communicate soft skills as core program outcomes. They should not be presented as indirect benefits or emotional side effects of the program. They are part of what the program is designed to produce. The language of “soft skills” may itself understate their importance. What the program builds is entrepreneurial agency: the ability to speak, decide, persist, ask, present, adapt, and act with greater confidence. In practical terms, #SheDIDIT's product is not only better business plans. It is women who are more able to inhabit the role of entrepreneur.

2.5 Translating vision into concrete business decisions

One reason the journey is transformative is that participants experience coaching as encouraging, supportive, and not judgmental. Coaches create a space in which women feel understood and able to express uncertainty without fear of being dismissed. This emotional safety is not separate from business development. It is what allows participants to ask questions, acknowledge weaknesses, and receive advice constructively.

As one participant explained:

“All coaches are very encouraging, very supporting. It always felt so good to be understood.”

This sense of being understood is especially important for migrant women entrepreneurs, whose business journeys are often shaped by language barriers, unfamiliar institutions, care responsibilities, and previous experiences of not being taken seriously. In this context, encouragement is not simply emotional support. It is a condition for participation and learning.

The interviews also show that coaching helps participants move from broad ambition to practical decision making. The journey matters because it forces entrepreneurs to clarify what they offer, who they serve, how they price, how they communicate, and how they present their business to others.

One participant described this movement from strategic clarity to implementation:

“She literally helped me through the macro level and the micro level, like how I could see myself from helicopter view and how this translated into my brochure, my services, how could I name them, my prices. So it was exactly what I needed.”

This quote captures one of the strongest mechanisms of the coaching journey. Participants are not only encouraged to believe in their idea. They are helped to turn that idea into decisions. The process links identity, strategy, and execution. It allows entrepreneurs to see the business as a whole, while also working through the details that make the business operational.

2.6 The journey builds discipline and accountability

Another reason the journey teaches more than the outcome is that it introduces structure and accountability. Some participants had already been in business for some time, but had not yet developed systematic routines around budgeting, pricing, planning, or follow up. Coaching helped them formalize these practices.

As one participant explained:

“It was the first time ever when she asked me that I did budgeting... even if I was in business for two years, I never did that properly.”

The value here lies not only in learning a technical skill, but in being brought into a more disciplined way of running a business. The coaching journey helps participants move from informal entrepreneurial activity toward more structured entrepreneurial practice.

Accountability was also described as a key feature of the process. Coaches followed up, noticed when progress slowed, and helped participants stay focused without making them feel judged.

As one participant recalled:

“The coaches, like, oh, you haven’t booked this this month. What happened?...gently.”

Another participant explained:

“I have really struggled to... be consistent, so it’s really helped me... to keep me focused on my goal.”

This form of accountability is effective because it is supportive rather than punitive. It helps participants remain connected to their goals while recognizing the complexity of their lives. For many women, especially those balancing business with family, work, migration, or administrative responsibilities, this gentle accountability is a critical part of the learning process.

2.7 Relatable coaches make the journey more credible

The interviews suggest that the journey is also effective because coaches are perceived as relatable and credible. Participants valued coaches who were entrepreneurs themselves, who understood the practical realities of building a business, and who could offer examples from their own experience. Where possible, matching by sector or language further increased the relevance of support.

This relatability makes coaching feel less abstract and more actionable. Advice is not received as generic instruction, but as guidance from someone who understands what it means to build, adapt, price, communicate, and sustain a business. This strengthens trust and makes participants more likely to act on the feedback they receive.

This same dynamic extends beyond the funded cohort: the impact of #SheFUND is wider than its funded cohort. While the funding decision is a central moment in the program journey, it does not determine whether participants derive value from the process. Across the interviews, both funded and non funded participants described concrete gains from coaching, application preparation, and pitching. These gains included greater clarity about the business model, stronger confidence in presenting the project, improved financial understanding, better pricing decisions, and a more structured sense of what the next stage of business development should look like.

“...for sure, it brings me a lot of courage... when somebody... appreciates you what are you doing.”

The founder echoes the mechanism saying:

“The most important thing is the confidence that you get when people give you money, or invest time and effort in you.”

This finding is important because it challenges a narrow interpretation of #SheFUND as a program whose impact can be assessed only through the entrepreneurs who receive loans. The interviews suggest that value is generated throughout the process, not only at the point of disbursement. Participants who were not selected for funding still passed through a structured entrepreneurial development journey. They refined their ideas, received coaching, learned to describe their business more clearly, and in some cases continued implementing the plan developed during the program. The program therefore produces a broader set of outcomes than the binary distinction between funded and not funded can capture.

For non funded participants, the process often produced practical and persistent learning. Several continued running their businesses after the program, sought alternative sources of funding, or applied lessons from coaching to improve their offer, pricing, customer targeting, or operational model. One non funded participant, for example, launched an administrative support consultancy and was generating revenue within a year of completing #SheMeansBusiness, following the plan developed with her coach. This example illustrates a wider pattern in the data: non selection did not necessarily mean that the program had failed to generate entrepreneurial progress. In some cases, the program helped participants move from an early idea to concrete business activity, even without financial support.

This illustrates what #SheFUND actually produces. #SheFUND does not only distribute loans. It builds entrepreneurial readiness across a wider group of women. Some receive funding immediately; others leave with clearer plans, stronger capabilities, and greater confidence to continue. Both outcomes matter. #SheFUND has the ability to generate value before, beyond, and independently of the loan decision.

2.8 Strategic Implications

Strategically, this finding suggests that #SheDIDIT should communicate #SheFUND not only as a funding opportunity, but as a structured entrepreneurial learning journey. The program’s value is not limited to who receives capital. It is also produced through the preparation, coaching, accountability, feedback, and confidence building that participants experience along the way.

This has three main implications. First, the journey itself should be intentionally designed as an impact pathway. Each stage of the process should have a clear learning function: application as self reflection, coaching as clarification and accountability, pitching as confidence building, feedback as redirection, and follow up as continued engagement. This would allow #SheDIDIT to show that the program creates value across the full applicant pool, not only among funded entrepreneurs.

Second, #SheDIDIT should measure the outcomes produced during the journey. These could include increased confidence, clearer pricing, improved budgeting practices, stronger business communication, greater consistency, and better ability to explain the business model. These indicators would help capture

the forms of progress that participants describe as transformative but that are often missed by conventional metrics focused only on loans disbursed, businesses funded, or revenue growth.

Third, the coaching model should remain relational and practice based. The interviews suggest that coaching works because it combines encouragement, accountability, sector relevant advice, and lived entrepreneurial experience. This means that coach selection and matching are strategic design choices. Coaches should not only have technical expertise, but also the ability to create trust, recognize uncertainty, and translate broad business ideas into concrete decisions.

3

Feedback Quality Shapes Applicant Outcomes

For non funded applicants, the quality of feedback after the pitch determines whether the experience empowers or erodes. When feedback is substantive, aligned with evaluation criteria, and delivered with care, non-selection can redirect and motivate. When feedback is light, or when criteria are misaligned with what was actually evaluated, the process fails its own stated values.

3.1 The Pitching Experience

Building on the findings regarding the relevance of the coaching experience, the interviews also explored participants' subsequent pitching journey. This stage emerged as an important moment of consolidation, where the learning developed through coaching and application preparation was translated into a public presentation of the business idea.

The key mechanism is that coaching and application preparation create transferable entrepreneurial capabilities. Participants do not leave the process only with the experience of having pitched. They leave with tools, language, and confidence that can be used in other entrepreneurial settings. A clearer business plan can support future funding applications. A stronger pitch can be adapted for conversations with customers, partners, or investors. Better financial understanding can inform pricing and planning decisions. Greater confidence can shape whether participants continue to pursue the business after rejection. These outcomes may be less visible than a loan, but they are highly consequential for entrepreneurial development.

This finding also reframes the meaning of the pitch. The pitch should not be understood only as a selection instrument used to allocate funding. It is also a learning event. For many participants, preparing for and delivering the pitch creates a moment of discipline, synthesis, and public validation. It requires them to translate their business into a concise, persuasive, and externally legible narrative. That experience has value even when the final decision is negative.

In this sense, the pitch is not merely the end of the application process. It is a developmental threshold. It marks the moment when a business idea moves from private aspiration or coaching discussion into a public entrepreneurial claim. Participants are asked to explain not only what they want to do, but why it matters, who it serves, how it will work, and why they are the right person to take it forward. This process strengthens both the business proposition and the entrepreneur's ability to inhabit the role of founder.

The value of the pitching experience therefore lies in its dual function. It allows #SheFUND to assess which businesses are ready for financial support, but it also allows participants to test, refine, and communicate their entrepreneurial identity. Even when the outcome is not funding, the process can leave participants with a stronger narrative, a clearer sense of direction, and a more concrete understanding of what is needed to move forward.

As explained by most non-funded entrepreneurs, it is a capability building exercise in itself:

"I pitched, and the reaction was... wonderful... how well it really clicked with me and how they loved the product."

"Before then I was pitching mostly to male audiences and it just did not relate so well. At this event, the vibe was amazing. The audience was wonderful."

At the same time, the persistence of these gains depends heavily on how the post decision phase is managed. For funded participants, the outcome provides validation, resources, and momentum. For non-funded participants, the continuation of impact depends on whether rejection is accompanied by useful feedback, emotional containment, and clear next steps. When non selection is communicated constructively, it can become a moment of redirection. When it is communicated weakly or without sufficient explanation, it risks undermining the confidence built during the earlier stages of the program. The fact that non funded participants can benefit from the process does not mean that the outcome is emotionally neutral. It means that the program has the potential to turn non selection into learning, but only if the feedback architecture is strong.

3.2 Feedback as a Design Variable

A third finding concerns the role of feedback after the pitch. For non funded applicants, the feedback moment is one of the most important points in the entire #SheFUND journey. It is the moment when the program can either consolidate the confidence, clarity, and entrepreneurial readiness built during coaching, or risk weakening them. Because participants invest considerable emotional and practical effort in preparing their application and pitch, the way the outcome is communicated matters greatly. The funding decision is not experienced only as an administrative result. It is interpreted as a signal about the value, credibility, and future potential of the entrepreneurial project.

For this reason, feedback quality should be understood as a central program design variable, not as a minor operational step. When feedback is clear, substantive, and delivered with care, non selection can become a productive moment of redirection.

“A no doesn’t mean that it’s not good. It just means that maybe... this is not the right place for you.”

It can help participants understand what was strong in their proposal, what needs further development, and what concrete steps they might take next. In this form, feedback extends the learning journey beyond the pitch. It transforms the funding decision into an opportunity for continued business development.

This is particularly important because #SheFUND already creates value before the outcome is known. Through coaching, application preparation, and pitching, participants develop business language, confidence, financial understanding, and a clearer entrepreneurial narrative. High quality feedback can protect these gains by helping participants interpret non selection as part of a longer entrepreneurial trajectory rather than as a final judgement. In other words, the feedback stage is where #SheDIDIT can ensure that the empowerment generated during the earlier phases is sustained after the decision.

The interviews suggest that participants value feedback most when it is specific, actionable, and connected to the criteria used in the selection process.

Those who actively asked and received feedback, particularly among non-funded entrepreneurs, highlighted its value along the following dimensions:

“I was able to present the pitch. And she told me what could be improved, and what was good already, which I really appreciate.”

“I took consideration of some of the points and have improved it.”

“it was an interesting experience... to get some feedback on me, on what she saw as positive points, and on which one where the points of improvement... it was all done in such a gentle manner.”

“I was reflecting a lot after the pitch, and I was really grateful what we heard from the people” — and on diverse feedback: “that’s the most valuable part.”

“the goal is just to present... get some useful feedback, so doesn't matter if it's too bad or good.”

“feedback is gold.”

Non funded applicants need to understand why the proposal was not selected, whether the issue concerned financial readiness, market validation, pricing, feasibility, repayment capacity, pitch clarity, or fit with the fund. They also benefit from knowing what they should do next: revise the business model, test the market further, strengthen financial projections, seek a different type of financing, or return in a future edition.

“I expected the jury to already know our businesses... I was a little bit disappointed... the feedback... was quite light.”

“I think I did not receive a systematic feedback about the pitch. I think I would, if I asked for it. Maybe I should have.”

“I didn't get any feedback... I would like to hear like this went well or didn't go well, or you should say more about that or that.”

This does not require feedback to be lengthy or resource intensive. What matters is that it is consistent, structured, and aligned with the program's developmental purpose. A simple feedback template could distinguish between strengths, areas for improvement, jury concerns, and recommended next steps. This would help ensure that all applicants receive comparable guidance while still allowing room for personalisation. It would also reduce the emotional ambiguity of non selection by making the decision easier to understand and easier to act on.

Seen in this way, improving feedback is a high impact opportunity to strengthen what #SheDIDIT already does well. The organization has built a process that helps women develop confidence, articulate their ideas, and present themselves publicly as entrepreneurs. The feedback stage is the point at which this value can be carried forward, especially for those who do not receive funding. Strengthening this stage would help ensure that non funded participants remain connected, motivated, and equipped with a clearer pathway for continuation.

3.3 Strategic Implications

This finding also has strategic implications for impact measurement. If non funded participants are considered part of the program's impact population, then feedback becomes one of the main tools through which that impact is sustained. A strong feedback process can increase the likelihood that participants continue their business, apply for alternative funding, return to #SheDIDIT, or remain active in the community. It can also support #SheDIDIT's credibility as a learning centred and care centred entrepreneurial ecosystem.

The main recommendation is therefore to formalize feedback as a core component of the #SheFUND journey. Feedback should be timely, criteria based, constructive, and oriented toward next steps. It should recognise the effort participants have invested, preserve the confidence built through coaching, and provide enough practical guidance to help them move forward. In doing so, #SheDIDIT can turn non selection into a more clearly supported moment of entrepreneurial redirection and maximise the developmental value of the entire program.

"I think my numbers were missing. I could have shown more" and "it was still a very nice experience... to get the feedback, it will be useful for my future ones, hopefully."

Some suggestions on how to improve were also shared:

"Maybe it would be good to meet one more time, or to have a like sort of results session where maybe we could hear that kind of feedback... I imagine contestants who didn't win that they could hear why."

Broadly, this has direct implications for how #SheDIDIT reports and measures success. If impact reporting focuses only on funded entrepreneurs, the organization risks systematically undercounting its own value creation. The funded cohort captures only one part of the program's effect. A wider impact framework should also track outcomes among non-funded applicants and coaching participants, including business continuation, alternative funding applications, revenue generation, improved business model clarity, pitch reuse, confidence gains, and continued engagement with the #SheDIDIT community.

4

The Loan Funds What Coaching Alone Cannot

Physical-product businesses face a hard financial floor before they can generate any revenue: minimum order quantities, tooling, packaging, and samples. Suppliers and manufacturers rarely offer gradual payment, so founders need a fixed sum committed upfront, regardless of how well the business plan has been prepared. The loan supplies exactly this kind of threshold capital that coaching alone cannot substitute for.

4.1 From Readiness to Execution: The Role of the Loan

This finding emerged directly from the three funded entrepreneurs interviewed for this study. Each described a point at which the business could not move forward without capital committed upfront, regardless of how well the plan had been prepared.

For product-based entrepreneurs, the first barrier is often not demand, motivation, or strategic clarity. It is the fact that suppliers and manufacturers require minimum order quantities, production commitments, samples, packaging materials, testing, or equipment before the business can begin selling. These costs cannot always be reduced gradually or paid for incrementally. A founder may know exactly what needs to be done, but still be unable to proceed because the required investment comes before revenue.

One participant explained why suppliers leave no room for gradual payment:

“You get some quotas of minimum orders that you have to make, and you also have to create samples and you have to do testing... If you don’t have the money, the fund, then it’s not possible... you need to have that money upfront once you start the process so you can advance. So if you don’t have that, then it stops there.”

This quote shows that the loan addresses a threshold problem. The issue is not a lack of preparation, but the indivisibility of certain business costs. A minimum production run cannot be purchased one unit at a time. Samples and testing must happen before market entry. Packaging must often be ordered in bulk. Without capital at this stage, the business does not merely grow more slowly; it may not be able to start operating at all.

Another described the same dynamic in the context of equipment and packaging:

“I bought a vacuum machine... a label machine... I also ordered ten thousand stickers for the jars. Those things were never money you have lying around when you are a complete person with a house, bills, and kids to pay for.”

This example highlights another important dimension of the loan: it reduces the gap between entrepreneurial ambition and personal financial reality. Many early-stage founders are not only managing a business idea, but also household responsibilities, rent, bills, childcare, and other everyday expenses. For these entrepreneurs, even relatively modest business investments can be difficult to absorb personally. The loan therefore creates room for business investment without requiring founders to compromise household stability.

For a third entrepreneur, the loan was valuable because it replaced a more expensive or less accessible financing route:

“That’s something I would have to take a loan elsewhere. I can pay it with this kind of funds.”

Here, the value of #SheFUND lies not only in access to finance, but in the quality and suitability of that finance. Without the programme, the entrepreneur may have needed to rely on commercial credit, personal savings, informal borrowing, or delayed investment. The loan therefore functions as a bridge between readiness and execution, allowing the founder to act on the business plan developed through coaching.

4.2 Strategic Implications

The strategic implication is that #SheFUND’s value for product-based businesses should be measured partly in terms of the specific, otherwise difficult-to-fund investments it enables. These include equipment, inventory, packaging, samples, testing, and minimum production runs. For these entrepreneurs, such investments are not secondary expenses. They are preconditions for entering the market.

This means that the programme’s impact should not be assessed only through standard indicators such as revenue growth, repayment performance, or business survival. These indicators remain important, but they may miss the earlier and more specific role of the loan: helping entrepreneurs cross the threshold between a validated idea and a sellable product. In some cases, the most immediate outcome of the loan is not rapid growth, but the ability to produce, package, test, or launch at all.

This finding also suggests that #SheFUND may be especially valuable for founders operating in sectors where early costs are lumpy and unavoidable. Food, fashion, crafts, cosmetics, and other physical-product businesses often require founders to commit resources before they can test the market fully. For these

businesses, a small loan can have a disproportionately large effect because it unlocks the first operational step.

At the same time, this insight points to a potential opportunity for programme design. #SheFUND could make the link between loan use and business model more explicit by distinguishing between different types of capital needs. Product-based entrepreneurs may require upfront production capital, while service-based entrepreneurs may need support for visibility, certification, digital tools, or client acquisition. Recognising these differences would allow the programme to better understand what kind of financing gap it is addressing in each case.

5

The Loan Functions as Protected Capital

For founders who are also primary caregivers or sole earners, every business expense competes directly with rent, bills, and family needs – a tension that can quietly stall investment. Because the loan is earmarked and repaid on a predictable schedule, it functions as ring-fenced money that does not have to be justified against the household budget, removing a recurring source of financial guilt and hesitation.

5.1 Money that does not compete with the household budget

A second important finding is that the #SheFUND loan does not function only as business capital. For some entrepreneurs, it also functions as protected capital: money that is clearly assigned to the business and therefore does not have to compete, either financially or emotionally, with the household budget.

This distinction is important because some founders are not only entrepreneurs. They are also primary caregivers, sole earners, or women carrying significant family and domestic responsibilities alongside their business. In these circumstances, business investment is rarely a neutral financial decision. Every expense can feel as if it is being taken away from rent, electricity, food, children, or other household needs.

The loan helps reduce this tension by creating a boundary between business money and household money. Because the loan is explicitly intended for the business, and because it is repaid through a predictable schedule, it becomes easier for founders to treat the money as legitimate business capital rather than as personal savings diverted away from the family.

In this sense, the loan does more than provide liquidity. It protects the entrepreneur's ability to invest. It allows business expenses to be framed as planned, justified, and separate from everyday household survival. This separation is especially valuable for founders who would otherwise hesitate to spend money on the business, even when the investment is necessary.

Two of the three funded entrepreneurs in this study, both of whom run their businesses largely alone, described this dynamic in similar terms. Their accounts show that the value of the loan lies not only in the amount received, but also in the way the money is separated from everyday household finances.

One participant explained that the loan made it possible to buy necessary business inputs without feeling that she was putting her personal budget at risk:

“It’s not a present, because you have to pay back. But it’s a nice moment. You can order those things without sacrificing your own... I found it really nice, just being able to say, okay, I can buy those stickers and not cry about it, and I’m not going to have money to pay my electricity this month because I bought that.”

This quote captures a type of financial pressure that is easy to overlook. The issue is not only whether the entrepreneur can afford a business purchase in absolute terms. It is whether she can justify spending money on the business when the same money could also be used to support the household.

For small businesses, these purchases are often necessary but emotionally difficult. Packaging, labels, materials, ingredients, tools, or small pieces of equipment may not appear large from the outside. Yet for a founder with limited disposable income, each purchase can trigger hesitation. The question becomes not only “Is this good for the business?” but also “Can I afford to take this risk away from my family?”

The loan reduces this burden by making the investment feel authorised. It gives the entrepreneur permission to buy what the business needs without experiencing the same level of guilt or fear that might come from using personal or household funds. In this way, the loan creates emotional space as well as financial space.

5.2 Predictable Repayment makes investments manageable

Another explained that the loan’s repayment structure, spread over monthly instalments rather than a single lump sum, was itself what made the investment feasible:

“It’s easier for me to pay back that amount monthly and being able to develop my product than not having, for example, already ten or twenty thousand euros that you have to give upfront yourself.”

This points to a second mechanism through which the loan functions as protected capital. It does not simply provide a fixed amount of money. It transforms a large upfront investment into a manageable monthly commitment.

For founders without substantial savings, this matters greatly. Many business expenses arrive before revenue is generated, but household income is often managed month by month. The loan reduces this mismatch. Instead of needing to accumulate a large sum before investing, the entrepreneur can act when the business needs it and repay gradually over time.

This structure can make the difference between postponing investment indefinitely and moving forward. It allows entrepreneurs to develop their product without waiting until they have personally saved enough to cover the full cost. The loan therefore supports not only access to capital, but also timing: it allows investment to happen when it is needed.

The interviews also suggest that the loan reduces a specific form of emotional friction: the guilt associated with spending on the business when household needs remain present. This is particularly relevant for founders who are responsible for others, or who do not have a separate financial cushion from which to invest.

In these cases, hesitation is not a sign of lack of ambition or lack of confidence. It reflects the real pressure of managing scarce resources across business and family life. A founder may believe in her business and still feel unable to spend money on it if that spending appears to threaten household stability.

The loan changes this calculation. Because the money is earmarked for business development, it helps the entrepreneur separate investment from sacrifice. The decision becomes less emotionally charged. The founder is not simply taking money from the household; she is using dedicated capital for a defined business purpose.

This is why the idea of protected capital is important. The protection is not only financial. It is also psychological. The loan protects the entrepreneur from having to constantly justify each business expense against immediate family needs.

5.3 Strategic Implications

This effect is rarely named in funding programme design, yet it directly addresses a source of financial tension that many entrepreneurs experience, particularly women who are also caregivers, sole earners, or responsible for household stability.

For #SheFUND, this means that the loan should not be understood only as access to finance in a technical sense. It also acts as ring-fenced capital. It protects the business investment from being constantly compared with household needs, and it protects the entrepreneur from the emotional burden of choosing between business development and family responsibilities.

Making this dimension explicit could strengthen how #SheFUND communicates the purpose of the loan. Rather than presenting it only as money to start or grow a business, the programme could also describe it as dedicated business capital that gives founders the space to invest without undermining their household budget.

This insight also has implications for impact assessment. The benefit of the loan may not appear immediately in revenue growth or profit figures. Its first effect may be that the entrepreneur finally feels able to purchase equipment, packaging, materials, or stock without fear of compromising personal financial stability.

In other words, the loan may first produce confidence to invest before it produces measurable business growth. This confidence is not abstract. It is tied to the practical and emotional relief of knowing that the money has a defined purpose, a repayment plan, and a boundary around it.

6

The Loan Fills a Financing Access Gap

None of the funded entrepreneurs interviewed described #SheFUND as one financing option they weighed against others. For migrant women without an established Belgian credit history, collateral, or professional network, conventional lenders are rarely a live alternative. The loan functions less as competitively-priced credit and more as the only accessible channel into formal financing.

6.1 The only viable channel, not the cheapest one

#SheFUND loan fills a financing access gap that many entrepreneurs would otherwise struggle to overcome. None of the funded entrepreneurs interviewed described #SheFUND as one financing option among several available alternatives. They did not present it as the cheapest loan, the most convenient loan, or the most attractive loan in a competitive market of financing options. Rather, they described it as the only realistic route through which they could access formal capital for their business.

This distinction is important. For many early-stage entrepreneurs, and particularly for migrant women, the problem is not only the cost of credit. It is whether credit is accessible at all. Conventional lenders often require an established financial history, collateral, stable income, administrative familiarity, and confidence navigating the local financial system. For entrepreneurs who are new to Belgium, or who do not yet have a long credit history or professional network, these requirements can make formal financing difficult to access in practice.

In this context, the value of #SheFUND lies not only in the loan amount or repayment terms. Its value lies in opening a door that would otherwise remain closed. The loan functions less as a marginal improvement on existing financing options and more as an entry point into formal business financing for founders who are not yet legible to conventional lenders.

None of the funded entrepreneurs interviewed described #SheFUND as one financing option among several they were weighing. This is analytically significant because it shows that the programme is not simply competing with other financial products. It is addressing a more basic problem: the absence of realistic financing alternatives.

One participant made the substitution explicit:

“That’s something I would have to take a loan elsewhere. I can pay it with this kind of funds.”

At first glance, this quote suggests that another loan might have been possible. However, its meaning is broader. The participant presents #SheFUND as the mechanism that allowed her to avoid searching for, negotiating, or depending on another form of credit. The loan gave her access to capital in a context where external financing would otherwise have been more difficult, more expensive, less suitable, or less certain.

For early-stage entrepreneurs, this certainty matters. When a business needs to purchase equipment, samples, packaging, stock, or services, the founder often cannot wait indefinitely while searching for credit. If financing is uncertain, the business decision is delayed. #SheFUND reduces that uncertainty by creating a structured and accessible financing route linked to the coaching and pitching process.

This means that the loan should not be understood only through the language of affordability. Its importance is not simply that it may offer better conditions than another loan. Its importance is that, for some founders, it makes formal financing practically reachable in the first place.

6.2 Credit invisibility and migrant entrepreneurship

The financing gap is especially relevant for migrant women entrepreneurs. Founders who are new to Belgium may have professional experience, education, business ideas, and entrepreneurial motivation, but still lack the local financial history that lenders typically use to assess risk. They may not have Belgian credit records, collateral, long-standing banking relationships, or documented business performance in the local market.

This creates a form of credit invisibility. The entrepreneur may be capable and committed, but the formal financial system has limited evidence through which to recognise her as fundable. In such cases, the barrier is not necessarily the quality of the business idea. It is the mismatch between what the entrepreneur can offer and what conventional lenders are able or willing to evaluate.

#SheFUND helps reduce this mismatch. Through its connection with #SheDIDIT, coaching, application preparation, and pitching, the programme creates an alternative pathway for assessing readiness. It allows entrepreneurs to demonstrate commitment, preparation, and business potential in ways that are not limited to collateral, credit history, or pre-existing financial records.

This is why the loan can be particularly valuable even when the amount is modest. For founders who are not yet recognised by mainstream lenders, access to any formal and structured financing can be a critical step. It validates the business as investable and gives the entrepreneur the means to move from planning to execution.

6.3 Networks as part of Financial Access

The interviews also show that access to finance is closely linked to access to networks. One participant described arriving in Belgium without a professional or entrepreneurial network:

“As a lawyer, as an expat here in Brussels, I didn’t have any network... I was just looking for places where I could learn about business, how I could actually launch this.”

This shows that financial exclusion is not only about banks. It is also about not knowing where to go, whom to ask, which institutions to trust, and how to enter the entrepreneurial ecosystem. A lack of network can make the entire business environment harder to navigate, including financing opportunities.

For entrepreneurs with established local networks, financing information often circulates informally through accountants, peers, mentors, business associations, incubators, banks, or family contacts. For migrant founders without these connections, the absence of a network can limit both knowledge and confidence. They may not know which financing channels exist, which ones are realistic, or how to approach them.

In this sense, #SheFUND does more than provide a loan. It embeds financing within a wider support environment. The programme combines capital with guidance, community, and a trusted organisational relationship. This makes the financing more accessible because it is not encountered as an isolated financial product, but as part of a process the entrepreneur has already entered and learned to navigate.

6.4 Strategic Implications

The strategic implication is that #SheFUND’s impact should be reported not only as the provision of credit, but as the creation of access where access would otherwise be limited or absent. This matters for how the programme explains its value.

If the loan is described only as a financing product, its contribution may appear relatively narrow. It may be evaluated mainly in terms of amount, repayment, interest, or business growth after disbursement. These indicators are useful, but they do not fully capture the access gap that the programme addresses.

For many funded entrepreneurs, the counterfactual is not a cheaper or more expensive commercial loan. The counterfactual is no suitable financing at all, delayed investment, reliance on personal savings, informal borrowing, or postponement of business development. In this light, the loan should be understood as enabling entry into formal financing rather than simply improving the terms of credit.

This also has implications for storytelling and impact measurement. #SheFUND can make explicit that it supports entrepreneurs who may not yet be served by mainstream finance, particularly migrant women, first-time founders, and entrepreneurs without collateral or established local networks. The programme's value is therefore not only economic, but institutional: it helps founders become visible, credible, and financeable within the local entrepreneurial ecosystem.

Overall, the evidence suggests that #SheFUND fills a financing access gap. It is not merely one loan among many. For some entrepreneurs, it is the first realistic, trusted, and structured channel through which business financing becomes possible.

Additional Emerging Insights: Growing Demand at the Pre and Post the #SheFUND Journey

Beyond the six core findings, the interviews point to unmet demand at both ends of the entrepreneurial journey.

5.1 The Need for Earlier Entry Points

Beyond the six core findings, the interviews also point to growing demand for #SheDIDIT support at both ends of the entrepreneurial journey - evidence that directly informs Recommendations 3 to 5 below. The interviews point to two distinct but connected gaps. The first appears before formal coaching begins, among women who are interested in entrepreneurship but are not yet ready to enter a structured business development program. The second appears after graduation, among women who have already developed their businesses through #SheDIDIT and are now facing more complex challenges related to growth, professionalization, and scaling. Together, these gaps suggest that #SheDIDIT is increasingly serving women across a broader entrepreneurial continuum than its current program architecture can fully accommodate.

At the entry point, the evidence suggests that some women arrive with ideas, ambitions, or early informal activities that are not yet ready for the intensity of #SheMeansBusiness or the formal requirements of #SheFUND. These women may not yet have a defined business model, a clear customer segment, financial projections, or the confidence to present themselves as entrepreneurs. However, they are not outside the target group. They are often at an earlier stage of the same journey. Several accounts point to long and non linear entrepreneurial trajectories, in which women carry an idea for years before they are able to act on it. For these participants, the first need is not advanced coaching, but a lighter and more exploratory entry point that helps them test whether entrepreneurship is possible, legitimate, and worth pursuing.

This matters because readiness is not only a technical condition. It is also shaped by confidence, time, language, networks, family responsibilities, migration experience, and exposure to entrepreneurial role models. A woman may have a meaningful business idea but lack the vocabulary, structure, or confidence to enter a formal coaching pathway. Without an earlier entry mechanism, these women may either remain on waiting lists, delay engagement, or enter coaching before they are fully prepared to benefit from it. A pre coaching pathway could therefore function as a bridge between inspiration and structured entrepreneurship support.

Such a pathway does not need to replicate #SheMeansBusiness. Its value would lie precisely in being lighter, more accessible, and less demanding. It could include introductory workshops, peer circles, business idea clinics, confidence building sessions, storytelling events, or short modules on “first steps” into entrepreneurship. The objective would not be to produce a full business plan immediately, but to help women clarify their idea, understand what entrepreneurship requires, and decide whether they are ready

to move into more formal coaching. In this sense, an earlier entry pathway would strengthen the pipeline into #SheMeansBusiness and #SheFUND by improving participants' readiness before they enter the core program.

The strongest evidence is that the formal track explicitly requires a formed idea. One coaching participant:

"...when you want to start in the track, you already have your idea... you need an idea. You don't have an idea, it's like no go."

One of the coaches confirms many applicants arrive before they're ready:

"they feel very unsure about themselves. Sometimes they just started and they haven't given their business idea enough thought and... enough time to develop even a little bit."

The multi-year incubation pattern is well documented. One funded entrepreneur carried her idea for years before acting:

"I was thinking, it's just weird that I would just start my own product... can I do it? It's just funny, funny idea. But yeah, little by little, I just got crazy about that idea" — and lacked any entry point: "as a lawyer, as an expat here in Brussels, I didn't have any network... I was at home with kids... I was just looking for places where I could learn about business."

5.2 The Need for Post-Loan or Scale-Up Support

At the other end of the journey, a "scale-up" gap also emerges. Some women who have grown through #SheDIDIT eventually move beyond the needs of early stage coaching. They begin to face questions related to hiring, legal structure, investor relations, market expansion, operational systems, partnerships, and growth strategy. These are qualitatively different challenges from those faced at the ideation or early launch stage. Yet participants who reach this point may not find an equivalent level of support within the existing program structure. This creates what can be described as a "cliff edge" after graduation: women are supported to develop and formalize their businesses, but once they begin to scale, the available support becomes less clearly defined.

"As a community person, to be honest, ... I wanted to be in contact with people making it."

This suggests that the community serves early-stage entrepreneurs but less high-growth profiles, and that aspirational role models are a gap.

This post graduation gap is important because it affects the long term impact of the model. If #SheDIDIT helps women become more confident, visible, and business ready, some of them will naturally progress toward more advanced entrepreneurial needs. Without a structured alumni or growth pathway, the organization risks losing contact with precisely those entrepreneurs who could become its strongest success stories, mentors, ambassadors, and evidence of long term impact. Supporting these women is not only beneficial for the entrepreneurs themselves. It also strengthens the wider #SheDIDIT ecosystem by creating role models for newer participants and by demonstrating that migrant women led businesses can move from idea to growth.

A post graduation pathway could take several forms. It could include advanced mentoring, targeted expert sessions, peer advisory groups, investor readiness support, legal and HR guidance, or curated referrals to specialized external partners. The goal would not necessarily be for #SheDIDIT to provide all advanced services internally. Rather, #SheDIDIT could act as a trusted connector, helping alumni access the right type of support at the right moment. This would allow the organization to remain focused on its core strengths while still preventing high potential entrepreneurs from falling out of the support ecosystem once their needs become more complex.

The coaching waiting list is the clearest organizational signal that current demand exceeds available capacity. This should not be seen only as an operational pressure. It is also evidence of the relevance and credibility of #SheDIDIT's model. Women are seeking access because the program addresses needs that are not being fully met elsewhere in the entrepreneurial support landscape. The existence of waiting lists therefore provides a compelling argument for investment in program growth, especially if expansion is designed strategically around the two pressure points identified in the study: earlier stage readiness and later stage scaling.

The strategic implication is that #SheDIDIT could benefit from articulating its work as a staged entrepreneurial pathway rather than as a set of separate programs. Such a pathway could include a pre coaching entry point for women still exploring their entrepreneurial identity, the #SheMeansBusiness core coaching journey for those ready to structure and develop a business, #SheFUND for those ready to seek financial support, and a post graduation or alumni pathway for entrepreneurs entering the growth stage. This would make the organization's model clearer to participants, funders, and partners. It would also help #SheDIDIT communicate that it does not simply deliver one program, but supports migrant women entrepreneurs across different moments of readiness, launch, and growth.

This finding is therefore not only about unmet demand. It is about the maturation of the #SheDIDIT ecosystem. The organization has created enough trust, visibility, and value that women now approach it from different stages of the entrepreneurial journey. Some need a first safe step into entrepreneurship. Others need advanced support to scale what they have already built. Responding to both needs would allow #SheDIDIT to deepen its impact, strengthen its pipeline, and build a more continuous support architecture for migrant women entrepreneurs.

Comparative Analysis: Funded and Not Funded Participants

Where funded and not funded experiences converge, and where the funding decision creates different trajectories.

This chapter systematically compares the experiences of funded and not funded participants across the core dimensions of the study. The comparison reveals both important convergences and meaningful divergences. The convergences show what defines the overall character of the #SheDIDIT and #SheFUND experience: community, recognition, confidence, and learning. The divergences show where the funding decision creates different trajectories, not only financially, but also symbolically, relationally, and strategically.

The analysis shows that the programme produces value for both groups. Not funded participants do not leave the process empty-handed. Many describe the coaching, pitching, and community experience as meaningful in themselves. At the same time, the comparison also shows that funding changes the depth and duration of programme impact. Funded participants receive not only capital, but also institutional recognition, continued visibility, and stronger integration into the #SheDIDIT ecosystem.

The distinction between funded and not funded participants should therefore not be reduced to a simple opposition between “success” and “failure.” Rather, it reveals two different forms of programme value. For funded entrepreneurs, the programme functions as a platform for implementation, validation, and continued growth. For not funded participants, the programme often functions as a formative experience that builds confidence, sharpens the business idea, and provides a first serious moment of entrepreneurial recognition. The strategic challenge is to ensure that the value created for not funded participants is not lost after the funding decision.

6.1 Convergences

The main convergence between funded and not funded participants is that both groups describe #SheFUND as more than a funding mechanism. Across outcomes, the programme is experienced as a process of entrepreneurial recognition, preparation, and belonging. Participants do not value the journey only because it may lead to a loan. They value it because it creates a space in which their ideas are taken seriously, their confidence is strengthened, and their entrepreneurial identity becomes more tangible.

This convergence is important because it shows that the programme’s impact begins before the funding decision. Coaching, community, and pitching generate value for participants regardless of whether they ultimately receive financial support. These elements help women clarify their business ideas, articulate their ambitions, and feel part of an entrepreneurial environment that understands their specific experiences. In this sense, the programme provides not only technical guidance, but also validation and social anchoring.

The shared experience across funded and not funded participants also suggests that #SheFUND's strongest value lies in the combination of structure and recognition. The process gives participants a concrete pathway to follow, while the community and coaching relationships make that pathway feel accessible and legitimate. This combination is particularly important for founders who may lack local networks, prior exposure to business support, or confidence navigating the Belgian entrepreneurial ecosystem.

The convergence, therefore, is not simply that all participants “benefit” from the programme. It is that they benefit from a similar underlying mechanism: being moved from isolation toward visibility, from uncertainty toward articulation, and from informal ambition toward a more recognised entrepreneurial position. Whether or not the participant is funded, the journey creates a meaningful shift in how she understands and presents herself as an entrepreneur.

6.2 Divergences

The main divergence between funded and not funded participants is not simply the presence or absence of financial support. Rather, the funding decision changes what the programme becomes for participants after the selection moment. For funded entrepreneurs, #SheFUND becomes a platform for continuation: the loan enables concrete investment, the selection provides external validation, and the ongoing relationship with #SheDIDIT can generate further visibility, contacts, and opportunities. In this sense, funding creates a cumulative effect. Material support, symbolic recognition, and ecosystem access reinforce one another.

For not funded participants, the programme can still be meaningful, but its value is more vulnerable to discontinuity. Coaching, pitching, and participation may generate confidence, clarity, and a stronger entrepreneurial identity, but these gains are less likely to be consolidated if the participant exits the active programme environment after the decision. The absence of funding therefore matters not only because capital is missing, but because the participant may also lose momentum, visibility, and structured connection to the ecosystem.

The divergence is therefore best understood as a difference in the durability of impact. Funded participants are more likely to experience #SheFUND as the beginning of a longer relationship with the organisation and the entrepreneurial community. Not funded participants are more likely to experience it as a valuable but time-limited process, unless there is a clear pathway for follow-up. This creates an asymmetry: those who receive the strongest validation also remain closest to the ecosystem, while those who may need continued support after non-selection risk becoming less visible.

This does not mean that the programme fails not funded participants. On the contrary, the evidence suggests that participation itself can be valuable. However, the comparison shows that the funding decision creates different post-programme trajectories. The strategic challenge is therefore to prevent non-selection from becoming a point of exit. A stronger follow-up pathway for not funded participants would help preserve the developmental value already created through coaching and pitching, while ensuring that the loan remains a distinctive but not exclusive source of programme impact.

Table 3: Comparative matrix across key analytical dimensions. Funded versus not funded participant experiences.

DIMENSION	FUNDED ENTREPRENEURS	NOT FUNDED ENTREPRENEURS
Technical skills	Strong gains in business planning, financial literacy, and pitching; reinforced through loan management	Gains during preparation phase; partially undermined if feedback is inconsistent or misaligned
Psychological confidence	High: coaching plus selection confer confidence and institutional backing	Moderate: preparation builds confidence; non selection requires individual resilience to sustain
Entrepreneurial identity	Strong consolidation: being chosen integrates the entrepreneur identity into self concept	Variable: some strengthen resolve; risk of identity fragility if process is poorly managed
Legitimacy effects	Strong: symbolic value of selection visible to clients, family, and institutions	Partial: participation confers some legitimacy; non selection withholds the full signal
Network and community	Significant: pitch event, alumni network, ongoing #SheDIDIT visibility	Limited post decision; community access during program phase only
Capital access	Concrete and otherwise unavailable: the loan funds threshold costs (minimum orders, equipment, samples) that coaching cannot substitute for, is experienced as capital protected from household budgets, and is often the only accessible financing channel.	Not applicable in the same form: non funded applicants do not receive this capital, though several sought alternative financing independently after the program.
Business outcomes	Concrete: investment, product development, revenue growth, formalisation	Indirect: motivation to seek alternatives; skills applied independently
Post decision engagement	Active: ongoing #SheDIDIT relationship, potential alumni and mentoring role	Weak: feedback only; no systematic follow up or reintegration

Recommendations for #SheDIDIT

Six recommendations follow directly from the evidence, each with concrete actions.

Six recommendations follow directly from the evidence. Each addresses a specific and identifiable gap in the program as it currently operates. They are presented with both the rationale drawn from the research and concrete actions that #SheDIDIT can take to implement them.

Recommendation 1: Name Community as a Core Program Output

Community is the program's most powerful differentiator and its most consistently valued feature across every participant group in this study. It is currently implicit in #SheDIDIT's offer and largely invisible in its impact reporting. It should be named, budgeted, and measured as a primary output rather than as an incidental benefit. The impact of this investment is not anecdotal. Community is the single most cited element across all seventeen conversations in this study.

Concrete actions:

- Schedule regular community events as a fixed program feature rather than as add ons dependent on available capacity.
- Create peer cohorts within coaching rounds so participants who go through #SheMeansBusiness together maintain connection after "graduation".
- Develop alumni touchpoints that keep funded and not funded graduates connected to the #SheDIDIT community over time.
- Reinforce community spaces, both digital and physical, as part of the #SheHub offer.
- Include a community engagement metric in #SheDIDIT's impact reporting framework.

Recommendation 2: Standardise and strengthen #SheFUND Feedback for all applicants

Feedback to not funded applicants must be aligned with the published evaluation criteria, structured, and sufficient for an applicant to understand specifically what would need to change for a successful future application.

Concrete actions:

- Brief jury members with a review of all written applications before the pitch event so they arrive familiar with each candidate.
- Provide jury members with a structured feedback template aligned to the published evaluation dimensions.
- Offer a 30 minute follow up session by video call to all not funded applicants within two weeks of the decision.
- Ask not funded applicants to rate the quality and usefulness of their feedback as part of a post decision survey.
- Review feedback quality annually and use findings to improve jury briefing and the feedback process.

Recommendation 3: Address the Coaching Capacity Gap structurally

The coaching waiting list is a fundraising asset, in that unmet demand quantified and reported makes a compelling case for investment. Both aspects should be managed deliberately and proactively.

Concrete actions:

- Introduce group coaching formats for early stage participants as an interim measure while one to one capacity is built.
- Pilot peer to peer coaching circles facilitated by #SheDIDIT coaches, with structured frameworks and accountability mechanisms.
- Develop a digital self paced onboarding resource that participants can use during the waiting period.
- Systematically collect, track, and report waiting list data as evidence of demand to current and potential funders.
- Model the fundraising case using waiting list numbers and the estimated value of delayed support.

Recommendation 4: Develop a Pre Entrepreneurial Pathway for young entrepreneurs

#YouthPreneurs serves the function of exploratory, identity oriented support for participants aged 15 to 28. There is no equivalent for adults who are not yet ready for #SheMeansBusiness but who would benefit from a lighter touch empowerment entry point. The evidence shows women on multi year journeys carrying ideas they cannot yet act on. This gap is both a missed opportunity and a pipeline constraint for #SheMeansBusiness.

Concrete actions:

- Design session pre entrepreneurial program for adults focused on values clarification, skills mapping, and idea generation.
- Position this program explicitly as a pathway into #SheMeansBusiness with clear progression criteria.
- Use peer facilitation and group formats to keep delivery costs low and community value high.
- Pilot with a small cohort and evaluate using the same impact framework as #SheMeansBusiness.
- Consider partnerships with community organisations already working with the target population to extend reach.

Recommendation 5: Create a Scale-up Support offer for established entrepreneurs

The program currently ends when an entrepreneur is no longer a pre starter or early stage founder. For the strongest profiles, those who have grown through #SheDIDIT and are now navigating hiring, investor relations, and market expansion, this creates a significant opportunity for #SheDIDIT to continue supporting its alumni.

Concrete actions:

- Design an alumni coaching or mentoring tier for graduates of #SheMeansBusiness who are in a growth phase. Needs may change, but space for different types of support services exist.
- Map specialist advisors in the #SheDIDIT network able to support scaling entrepreneurs and formalise a referral pathway.
- Explore partnerships with Belgian and European accelerator programs that serve the scaling entrepreneur profile.

- Host an annual alumni event that keeps graduates connected to the #SheDIDIT community and to each other.
- Collect data on post graduation trajectories of #SheMeansBusiness alumni to build the evidence base for this offer.

Recommendation 6: Make Psychological and Mindset Support an explicit feature of Coaching

The psychological dimension of coaching, the validation, the identity work, the moment when a coach says this is real and you can do it, is consistently identified as the most transformative element of the program. It currently operates as an implicit and unmarked feature. Making it explicit is a low cost and high impact change that benefits participants, coaches, and funders alike.

Concrete actions:

- Include psychological support explicitly in #SheDIDIT's description of the #SheMeansBusiness coaching offer.
- Train coaches to articulate the psychological dimension of what they do so they can name it for participants.
- Include a wellbeing and confidence measure in the pre and post coaching evaluation that participants complete.
- Use participant accounts of psychological impact in #SheDIDIT's external communications and funding applications.
- Consider whether a partnership with a wellbeing provider would strengthen capacity to serve participants who need deeper support.

Implications for the Field

What the #SheFUND case suggests for the European Microfinance Network and for gender responsive program design more broadly.

8.1 For the European Microfinance Network

The #SheFUND case demonstrates clearly that the impact of financial inclusion programs for migrant women entrepreneurs cannot be adequately captured by loan disbursement rates, repayment performance, or business survival statistics alone. The most significant effects in this study are in the domains of skills development, confidence, entrepreneurial identity, and social connection. These are outcomes that standard microfinance evaluation frameworks do not capture systematically, and therefore cannot count, cannot report, and cannot use to make the case for sustained investment.

EMN is well positioned to use this evidence to advocate for holistic impact measurement frameworks across its membership, particularly for programs targeting structurally excluded populations for whom the barriers to entrepreneurial success are as much psychological and social as they are financial. This advocacy is not merely principled. It is strategic: organisations that can demonstrate the full range of their impact, not only the subset that current frameworks can measure, will attract more sustained and diverse funding.

EMN should also consider actively promoting the #SheDIDIT model as a replicable non financial services innovation within the European microfinance landscape. Key replicable elements include the coaching as prerequisite structure; the empowerment framing that begins with potential rather than disadvantage; the deliberate composition of a women focused and entrepreneurially literate evaluation jury; and the community building infrastructure that runs through every element of the program.

A longitudinal follow up study at 18 to 24 months post #SheFUND participation, tracking both funded and not funded cohorts, would answer the questions this study cannot. Does the capability gained through coaching persist? Does the business survive and grow? Does the legitimacy signal from a #SheFUND selection translate into long term institutional access? This study provides the baseline. A follow up would provide the trajectory.

8.2 Design Principles for Gender Responsive Financial Inclusion

For organisations designing financial support programs for migrant women entrepreneurs, the #SheFUND case suggests five principles grounded in the evidence and generalisable beyond the Belgian context.

1

Begin with potential, not disadvantage.

Framing matters. Programs that start from strength and ambition produce different participant experiences and outcomes than those framed around vulnerability and exclusion. #SheDIDIT's explicit commitment to treating migration background as a form of capital rather than a deficit shapes every interaction participants have with the program.

2

The process is the product.

The selection and feedback process is itself an empowerment intervention. Invest in its quality as seriously as in the financial product. A poorly designed or inconsistently executed selection process does not merely fail to empower. It may actively disempower.

3

Audience composition matters.

The experience of pitching to a women focused, entrepreneurially literate jury is qualitatively and demonstrably different from pitching to a mixed or male dominated panel. Program design should be deliberate about who evaluates and what relational context the evaluation creates.

4

Non financial services and financial access are not alternatives.

The evidence shows that coaching and community produce capability and identity effects that financial access alone cannot generate. The two should be designed together, not offered as separate tracks.

5

Community is infrastructure.

The sense of belonging to a space that understands one's intersectional experience is not a supplementary benefit. It is the mechanism through which other program effects become possible. Build it deliberately, fund it adequately, and measure it systematically.

Conclusion

#SheFUND does considerably more than provide capital.

This study set out to understand how participating in #SheDIDIT's loan selection and coaching process shapes migrant women entrepreneurs' skills, confidence, and perceived legitimacy in Belgium. The answer is clear, and it is more interesting and more nuanced than a simple financial impact story.

#SheFUND does what it sets out to do: it provides interest free capital to migrant women entrepreneurs who cannot access conventional financing. It enables specific, time sensitive investments that advance the trajectory of real businesses. The women who received #SheFUND loans in this study are growing, expanding, and building. But #SheFUND does considerably more than provide capital. It builds capabilities through coaching and application preparation. It provides a structured and institutionalised site for entrepreneurial identity development. It confers legitimacy through a credible and transparent selection process. And it connects participants to a community that understands, in a full and intersectional sense, what they are trying to do and who they are.

The most significant finding of this study is that these non financial effects operate across the full applicant pool, not only among those who receive funding. This has a direct and actionable implication for program design: the quality of the process matters as much as the quality of the financial product. The experience of not funded applicants deserves as much deliberate attention as the experience of funded ones. And the success metrics of the program should reflect the full scope of its impact, not the narrow subset that current frameworks are equipped to count.

Belgium's entrepreneurial ecosystem does not yet reflect the diversity of its population. One in three Belgians has a migration background. A fraction of that proportion is visible in business ownership, investment networks, or entrepreneurial support ecosystems. #SheDIDIT was founded precisely to close this gap, not by treating migration background as a disadvantage to be managed, but by treating it as an asset waiting to be unlocked. The evidence from this study suggests strongly that the model is working. The task now is to scale it, fund it adequately, refine it where the evidence shows gaps, and hold it to its own high standards.

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Annexes

Annex A: Interview Guide Sample · Annex B: Thematic Codebook Summary

Annex A: Interview Guide Sample

Section 1: Personal and Professional Background

1. Could you tell us a bit about yourself: where you are from, how long you have been in Belgium, and what your life looks like today?
2. What motivated you to start your own business, and when did you first have the idea?
3. What have been the most significant challenges you faced in setting up or growing your business?

Section 2: Discovering #SheDIDIT and the Application Process

1. How did you first hear about #SheDIDIT and the #SheFUND program?
2. What made you decide to apply? What were your expectations at that point?
3. Could you walk us through your experience of the application and preparation process?
4. Did you receive coaching or mentoring as part of the process? What was most valuable?

Section 3: The Decision Moment

1. How did you find out about the decision? What was your reaction?
2. What did the pitching experience feel like? How would you describe the atmosphere and the jury?
3. What did the decision mean to you, beyond the financial dimension?

Section 4: Post Decision Trajectory

1. How has your business developed since the program?
2. Has the experience changed how you see yourself as an entrepreneur or how you present yourself to others?
3. Has your relationship with #SheDIDIT continued? How?

Section 5: Reflections and Recommendations

1. If you could change one thing about the #SheFUND process, what would it be?
2. What advice would you give to another migrant woman entrepreneur who is considering applying?

Annex B: Thematic Codebook Summary

CODE	DESCRIPTION	EXAMPLE INDICATOR
CAP TECH	Technical capability gains	Participant mentions a specific new skill: business planning, pricing, pitching, financial modelling
CAP PSY	Psychological capability and confidence	Self described confidence increase; reduced imposter syndrome; willingness to claim the entrepreneur label
ID SHIFT	Entrepreneurial identity shift	Use of the word entrepreneur before and after engagement; changed self description
ID PUBLIC	Public presentation of identity	Changed behaviour in client, network, or institutional contexts post program
LEG POS	Positive legitimacy signal	Selection confers recognition; others treat applicant differently post selection
LEG NEG	Legitimacy at risk	Non selection experienced as delegitimising; feedback inconsistency noted by participant
COMM	Community value	Sense of belonging; peer connection; references to the room or the #SheDIDIT space
COACH	Coach impact	Specific coach behaviour described as influential; named coach moments
PROCESS	Process quality	Comments on application, evaluation, or feedback procedural fairness
GENDER	Gendered barriers	References to caregiving, imposter syndrome, or male dominated environments
REC	Recommendations	Explicit or implicit suggestions for program improvement

Table 4: Thematic codebook summary. Full codebook with code frequencies available upon request.